Revision, Negation, and Incompleteness in Melville's *Billy Budd* Manuscript

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CC BY

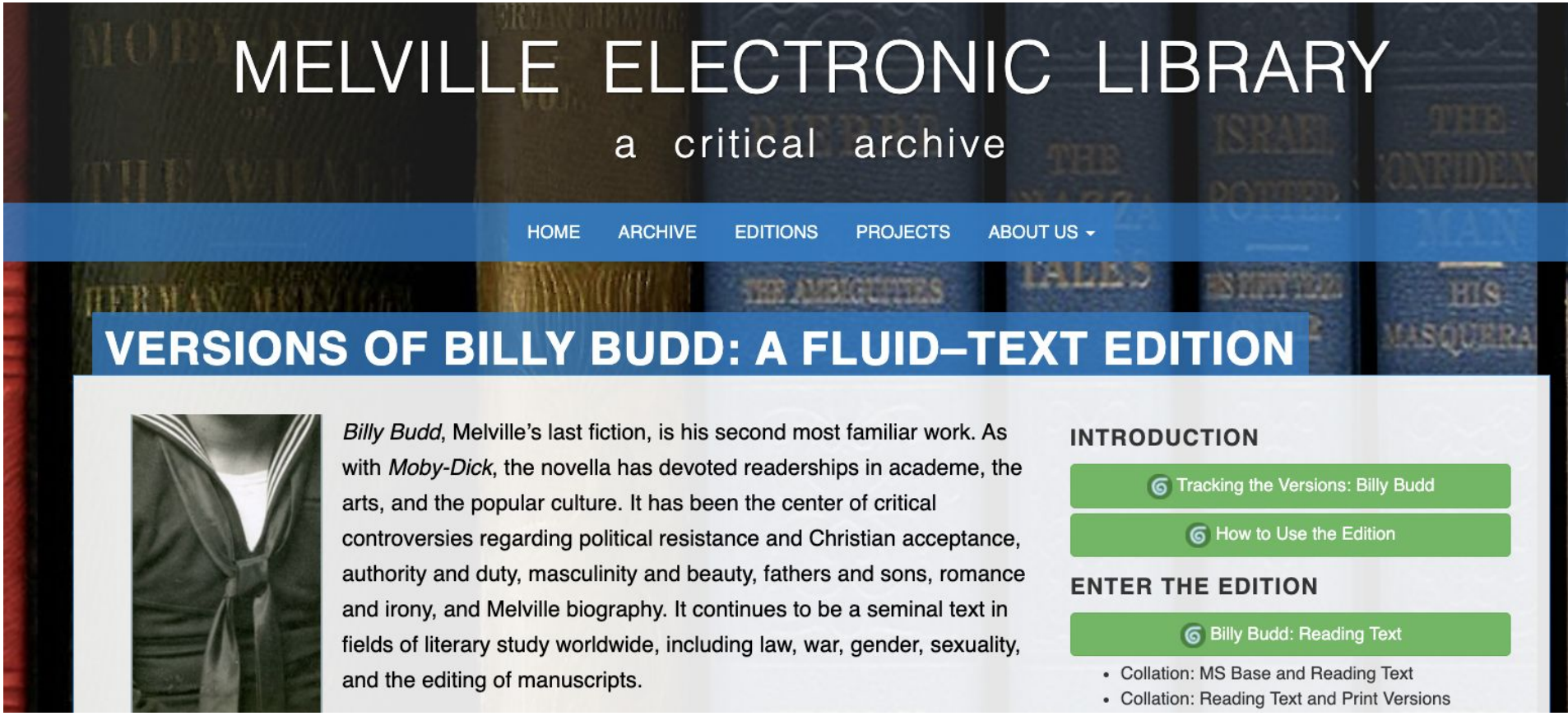
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Access slides

https://bit.ly/3xpoKbE

Some Background

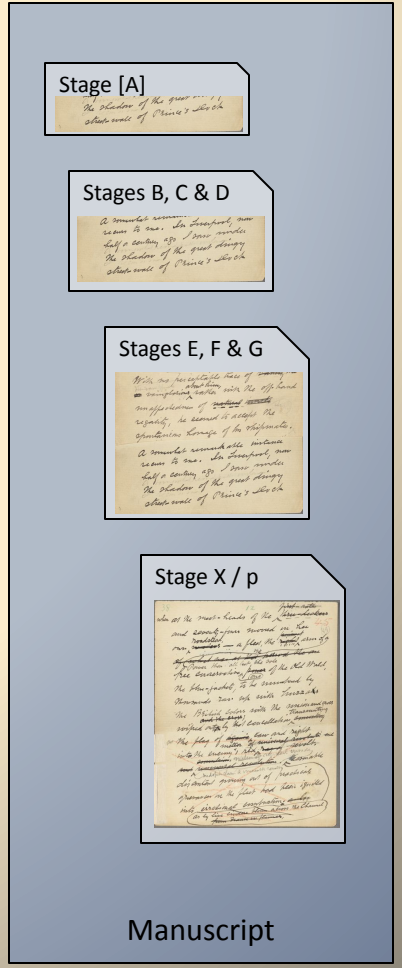
https://melville.electroniclibrary.org/versions-of-billy-budd



How Billy Grew

At least **8 stages** of composition

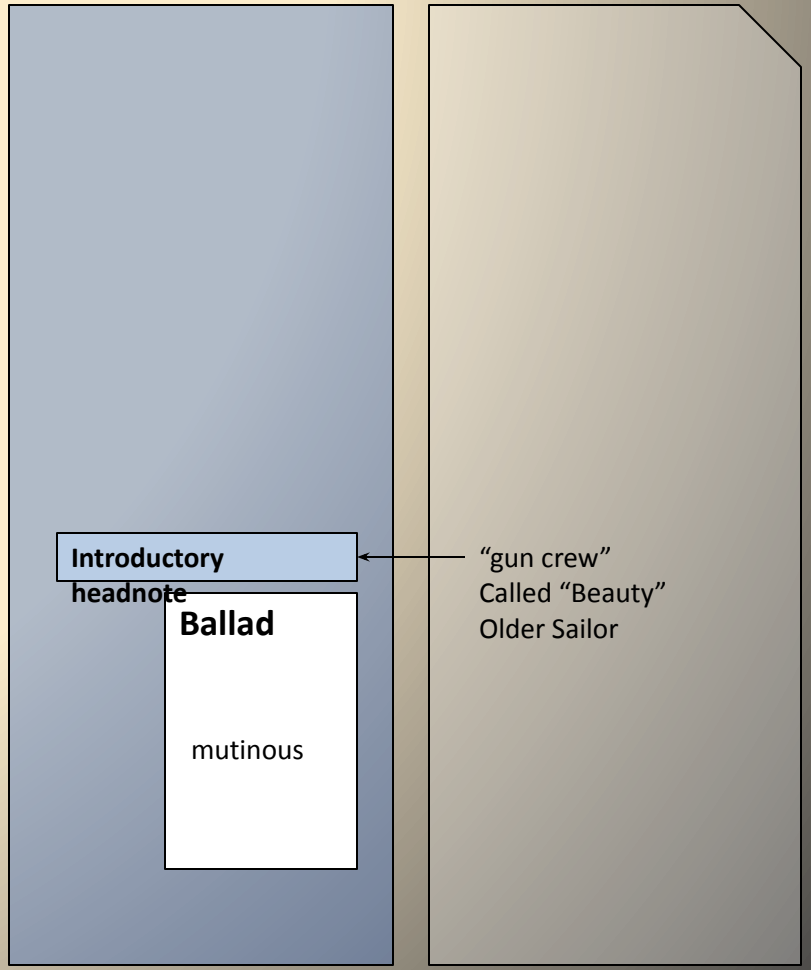
3 Versions (fair copy stages with revisions in pen and pencil)



Slides courtesy John Bryant

How Billy Grew

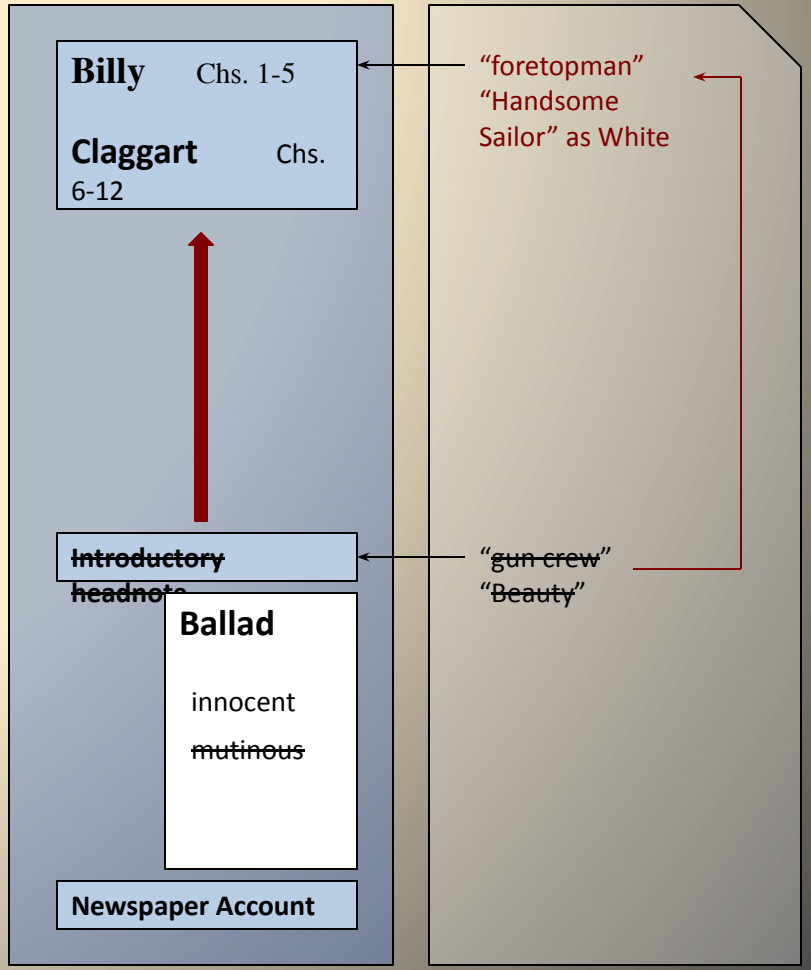
Stage A



Slides courtesy John Bryant

How Billy Grew

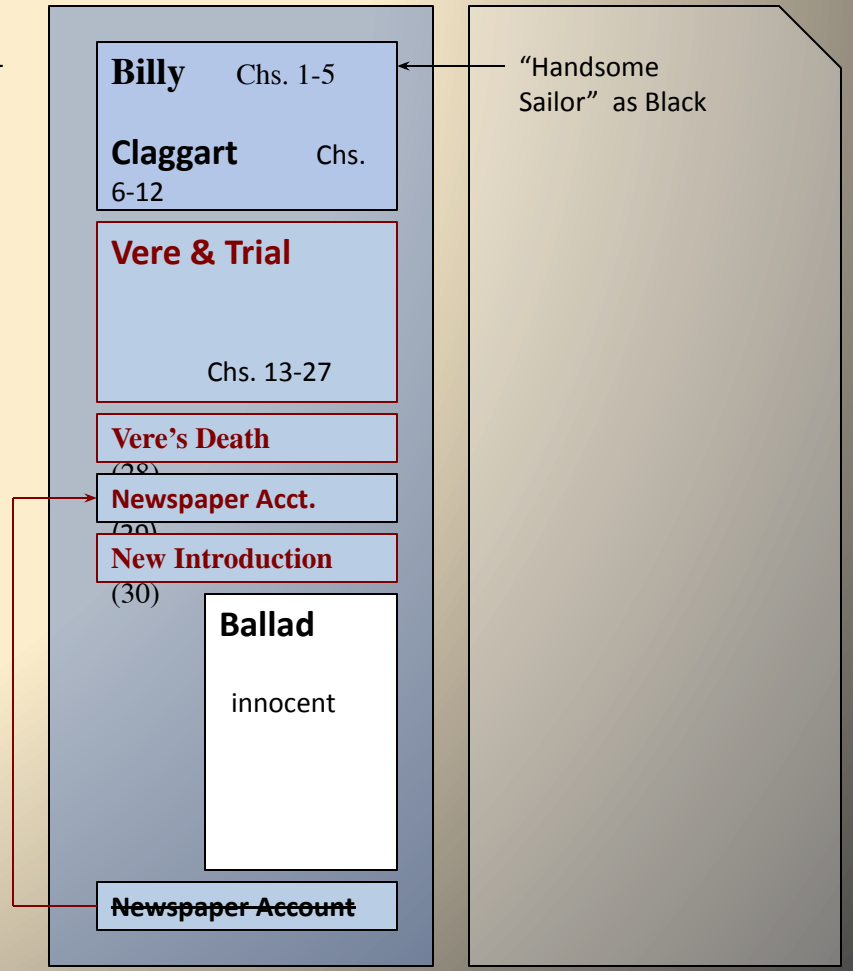
Stages B, C, D



Slides courtesy John Bryant

How Billy Grew

Stages F & G



Slides courtesy John Bryant

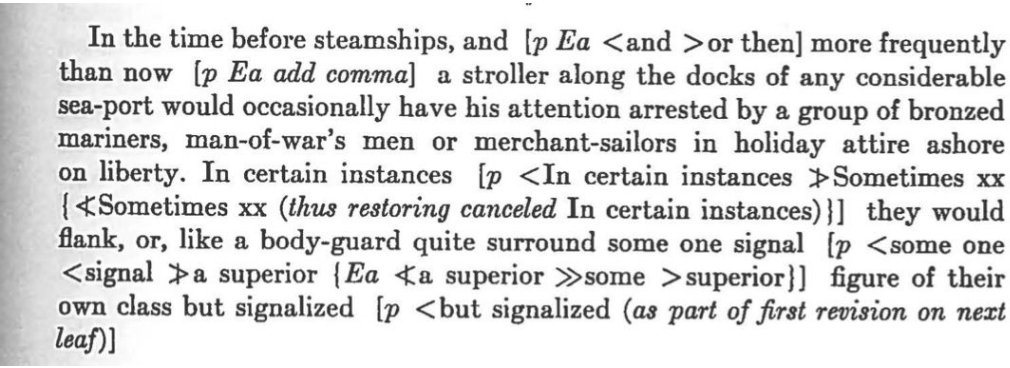
Principles of Fluid Text Editing

- A fluid text (FT) is any work that exists in more than one version. The material foundation is the version (the ‘version’ being a substantial change to a text through revision, re-arrangement, a new edition, or an adaptation).
- FT challenges the fixity of the material text, suggesting that, e.g.,, a manuscript, is an ‘approximation of thought’ (or the ‘flow of creativity’) rather than the ‘material foundation’ of it.
- Like genetic criticism, FT concerns writing as *process*: not only the creative process but the ‘forces that drive textual fluidity’ (which can include collaborators and publishers).
- Editors therefore record the material instantiations of textual fluidity (i.e. versions) and provide ‘revision narratives’ to help readers understand the process.
- FT editing attempts a compromise between the major schools of scholarly editing: critical (copy-text) editing, genetic editing, and social(ised) text editing.

(John Bryant, *The Fluid Text*, pp. 1–11)

Genetic transcription into TEI XML encoding

Billy Budd, Sailor, ed. Harrison Hayford and Merton Sealts, Jr. (U of Chicago P, 1962)



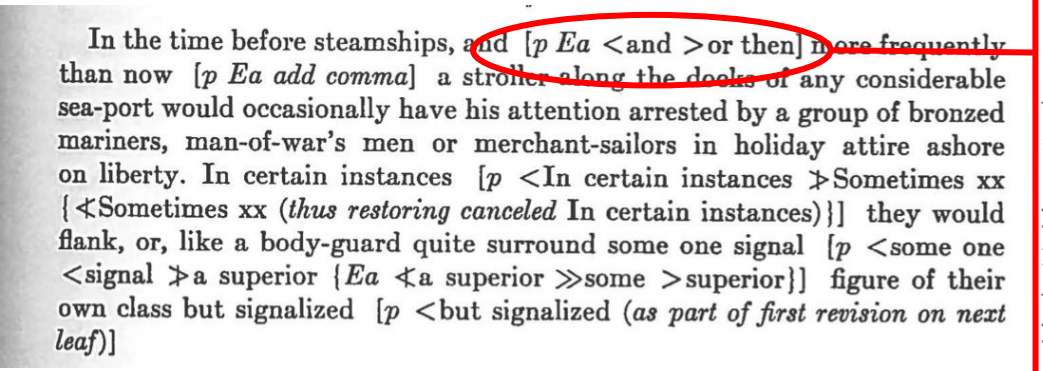
In the time before steamships, and [*p Ea* <and >or then] more frequently than now [*p Ea add comma*] a stroller along the docks of any considerable sea-port would occasionally have his attention arrested by a group of bronzed mariners, man-of-war's men or merchant-sailors in holiday attire ashore on liberty. In certain instances [*p* <In certain instances ⋗Sometimes xx {⋖Sometimes xx (*thus restoring canceled* In certain instances)}] they would flank, or, like a body-guard quite surround some one signal [*p* <some one <signal ⋗a superior {*Ea* ⋖a superior ≫some >superior}] figure of their own class but signalized [*p* <but signalized (*as part of first revision on next leaf*)]

Melville Electronic Library edition

```
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<lb/>In the time before steamships,
<lb/><del rend="single-stroke _ink1"
hand="#HM" change="StEa" facs="#img_5-0020"
>and</del>
<metamark place="inline" function="caret"
rend="caret _ink1" change="StEa"
facs="#img_5-0030" >^</metamark>
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facs="#img_5-0019" ><del rend="erasure _HMp"
hand="#HM" change="StEa" facs="#img_5-0019"
>or then</del>
<add place="inline" rend="no-caret _ink2"
hand="#HM" change="StEa" facs="#img_5-0019"
>or then</add></subst></add>
more frequently than now<add
facs="#img_5-0024" place="inline"
rend="no-caret">,</add> a stroller
<lb/>along the docks of any considerable
<lb/>sea-port would occasionally have his
</ab>
```

Genetic transcription into TEI XML encoding

Billy Budd, Sailor, ed. Harrison Hayford and Merton Sealts, Jr. (U of Chicago P, 1962)



In the time before steamships, and [*p Ea* <and >or then] more frequently than now [*p Ea add comma*] a stroller along the docks of any considerable sea-port would occasionally have his attention arrested by a group of bronzed mariners, man-of-war's men or merchant-sailors in holiday attire ashore on liberty. In certain instances [*p* <In certain instances ⩾Sometimes xx {⩽Sometimes xx (*thus restoring canceled* In certain instances)}] they would flank, or, like a body-guard quite surround some one signal [*p* <some one <signal ⩾a superior {*Ea* ⩽a superior ≫some >superior}] figure of their own class but signalized [*p* <but signalized (*as part of first revision on next leaf*)]

Melville Electronic Library edition

```
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<lb/>In the time before steamships,
<lb/><del rend="single-stroke _ink1"
hand="#HM" change="StEa" facs="#img_5-0020"
>and</del>
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hand="#HM" change="StEa" facs="#img_5-0019"
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hand="#HM" change="StEa" facs="#img_5-0019">
or then</add></subst></add>
more frequently than now<add
facs="#img_5-0024" place="inline"
rend="no-caret">,</add> a stroller
<lb/>along the docks of any considerable
<lb/>sea-port would occasionally have his
</ab>
```

Fluid Text Protocols

1. Diplomatic transcription (with genetic encoding) of the manuscript in TEI.
2. Base (reading) text generated from a ‘cleaned-up’ diplomatic text.
3. Critical reading text emends base text and records contextual notes and revision narrative notes.

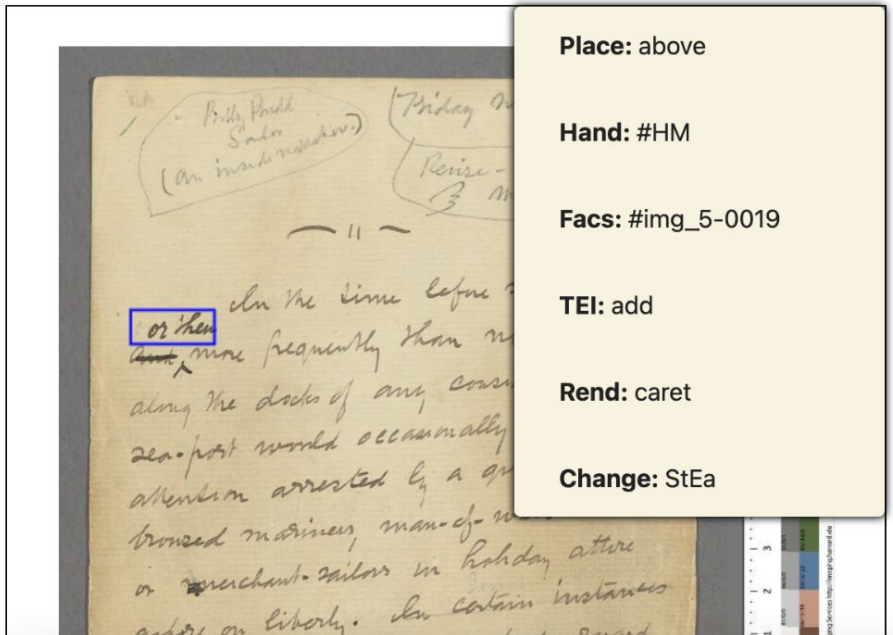
… And…

A fluid text edition shows all of these versions, and does not privilege one over the other, and attempts to provide narratives of the variation between them.

Diplomatic (and Genetic) Transcription of Chapter 1 of *Billy Budd* in TEI XML

Next Leaf

Diplomatic Base



Place: above

Hand: #HM

Facs: #img_5-0019

TEI: add

Rend: caret

Change: StEa

Altered Text

or then

—//—

In the time before steamships,

or then
~~and~~ ^ more frequently than now , a stroller

along the docks of any considerable

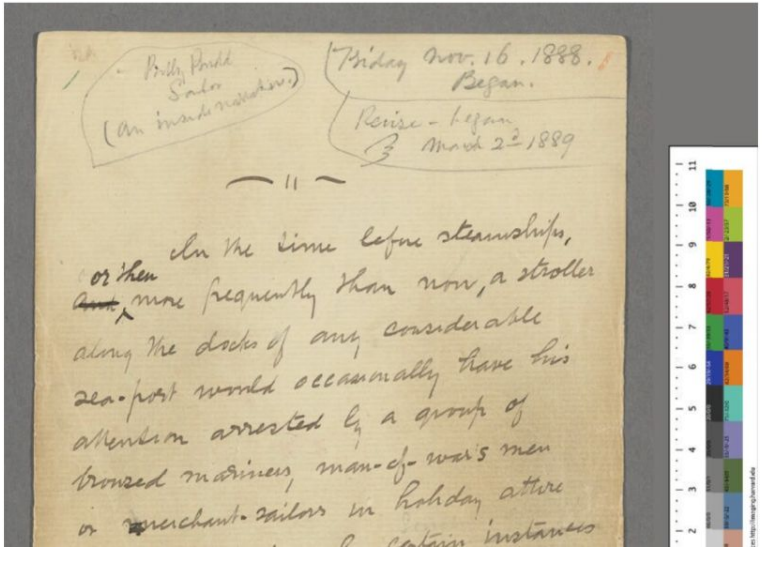
sea-port would occasionally have his

attention arrested by a group of

“Base” text

Next Leaf

Diplomatic | Base



In the time before steamships,

or then more frequently than now , a stroller

along the docks of any considerable

sea-port would occasionally have his

attention arrested by a group of

bronzed mariners, man-of-war's men

Melville Electronic Library Critical Reading Text of *Billy Budd*

Melville Electronic Library

Melville Electronic Library >> Versions of Billy Budd

Chapters

Dedication
Chapter 1
Chapter 2
Chapter 3
Chapter 4
Chapter 5
Chapter 6
Chapter 7
Chapter 8

Chapter 1

IN THE TIME BEFORE STEAMSHIPS, or then more frequently than now, a stroller along the docks of any considerable sea-port would occasionally have his attention arrested by a group of bronzed mariners, man-of-war's men or merchant-sailors in holiday attire ashore on liberty. In certain instances they would flank, or, like a body-guard quite surround some superior figure of their own class, moving along with them like Aldebaran among the lesser lights of his constellation. That signal object was the "Handsome Sailor" of the less prosaic time alike of the military and merchant navies. With no perceptible trace of the vainglorious about him, rather with the off-hand unaffectedness of natural regality, he seemed to accept the spontaneous homage of his shipmates.

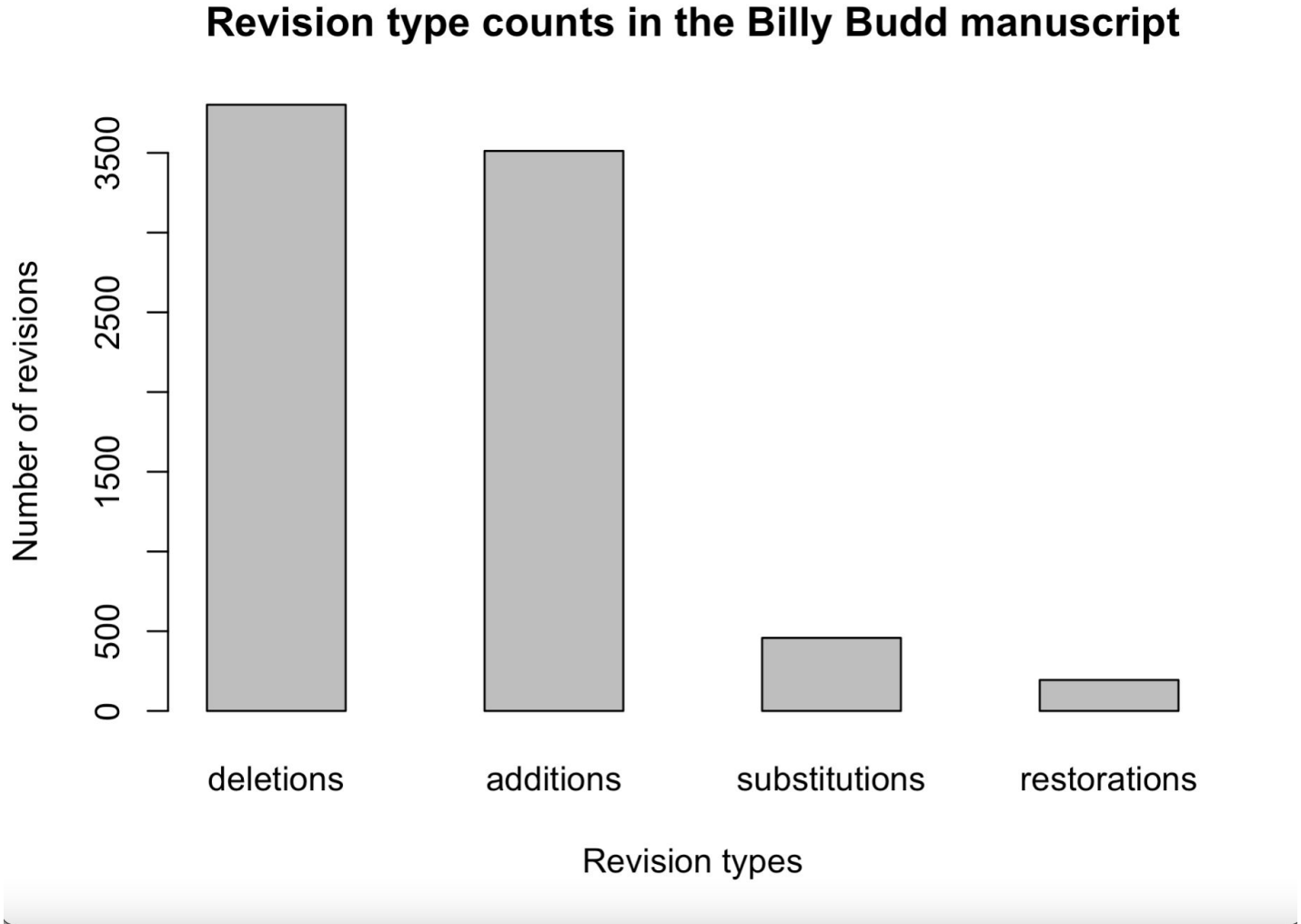




Example: Melville Electronic Library *Billy Budd* TEI XML

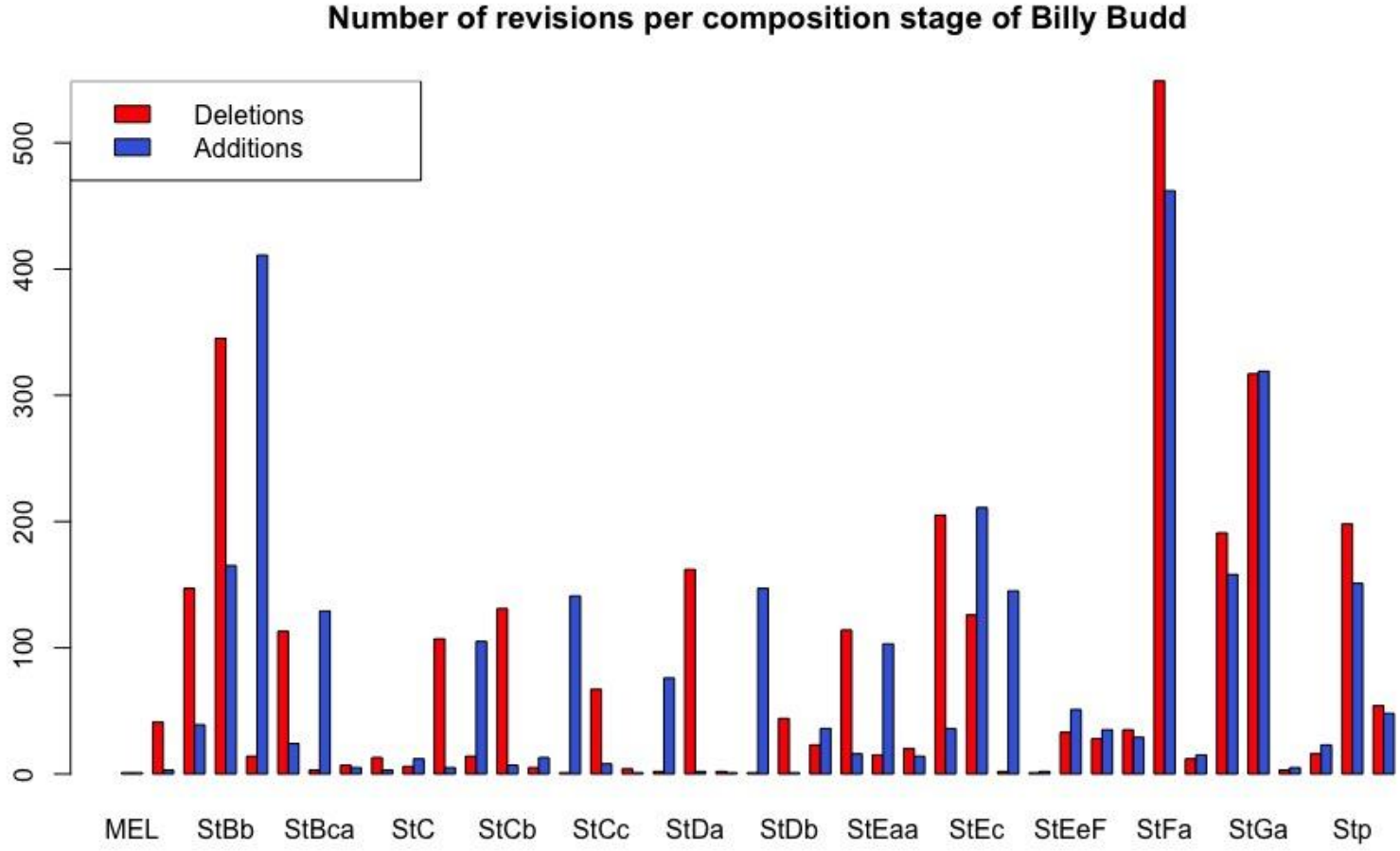
```
<text>
  <body>
<milestone n="3" unit="leaf" /><pb facs='#img_3'/>
<ab>
<metamark place="margin(bottom) margin(left)" function="folio" rend="no-caret _HMp" change="Ht" facs="#img_3-0014" >1</metamark>
<add place="inline" rend="no-caret _HMp" hand="#HM" change="Stp" facs="#img_3-0012" >Dedicated
  <lb/>to
  <lb/>Jack Chace
  <lb/>Englishman
  <lb/>Wherever <del rend="single-stroke _HMp" hand="#HM" change="Stp" facs="#img_3-0003" >he</del> <metamark place="inline"
function="insertion-device" rend="caret _HMp" change="Stp" facs="#img_3-0002" >^</metamark> <add place="margin(right)" rend="bubble
_HMp" hand="#HM" change="Stp" facs="#img_3-0001" >that great heart</add> may now be
  <lb/>Here on earth or <metamark place="inline" function="caret" rend="caret _HMp" change="Stp" facs="#img_3-0004" >^</metamark> <add
place="above" rend="caret _HMp" hand="#HM" change="Stp" facs="#img_3-0005" >harbored</add> in Paradise
  <lb/>Captain of the Main-<subst facs="#img_3-0007" ><del rend=" _HMp" hand="#HM" change="Stp" facs="#img_3-0007" >top</del><add
place="inline" rend="no-caret _HMp" hand="#HM" change="Stp" facs="#img_3-0007" >Top</add></subst> <metamark place="below"
function="caret" rend="insertion-device _HMp" change="Stp" facs="#img_3-0011" >^</metamark><lb/><add place="margin(bottom)" rend="bubble
_HMp" hand="#HM" change="Stp" facs="#img_3-0010" >in the year 1843</add>
  <lb/>in <metamark place="inline" function="caret" rend="caret _HMp" change="Stp" facs="#img_3-0009" >^</metamark> <del
rend="single-stroke _HMp" hand="#HM" change="Stp" facs="#img_3-0008" ><add place="margin(left)" rend="bubble _HMp" hand="#HM"
change="Stp" facs="#img_3-0008" >historic</add></del> the U. S. Frigate
  <lb/>"United States"</add>
  <lb/><metamark place="margin(bottom)" function="composition-information" rend="no-caret _HMp" change="Stp" facs="#img_3-0013" ><add
place="above" rend="no-caret _HMp" hand="#ESM" change="Stp" facs="#img_3-0013" >For Billy Budd</add></metamark>
  <lb/>
```

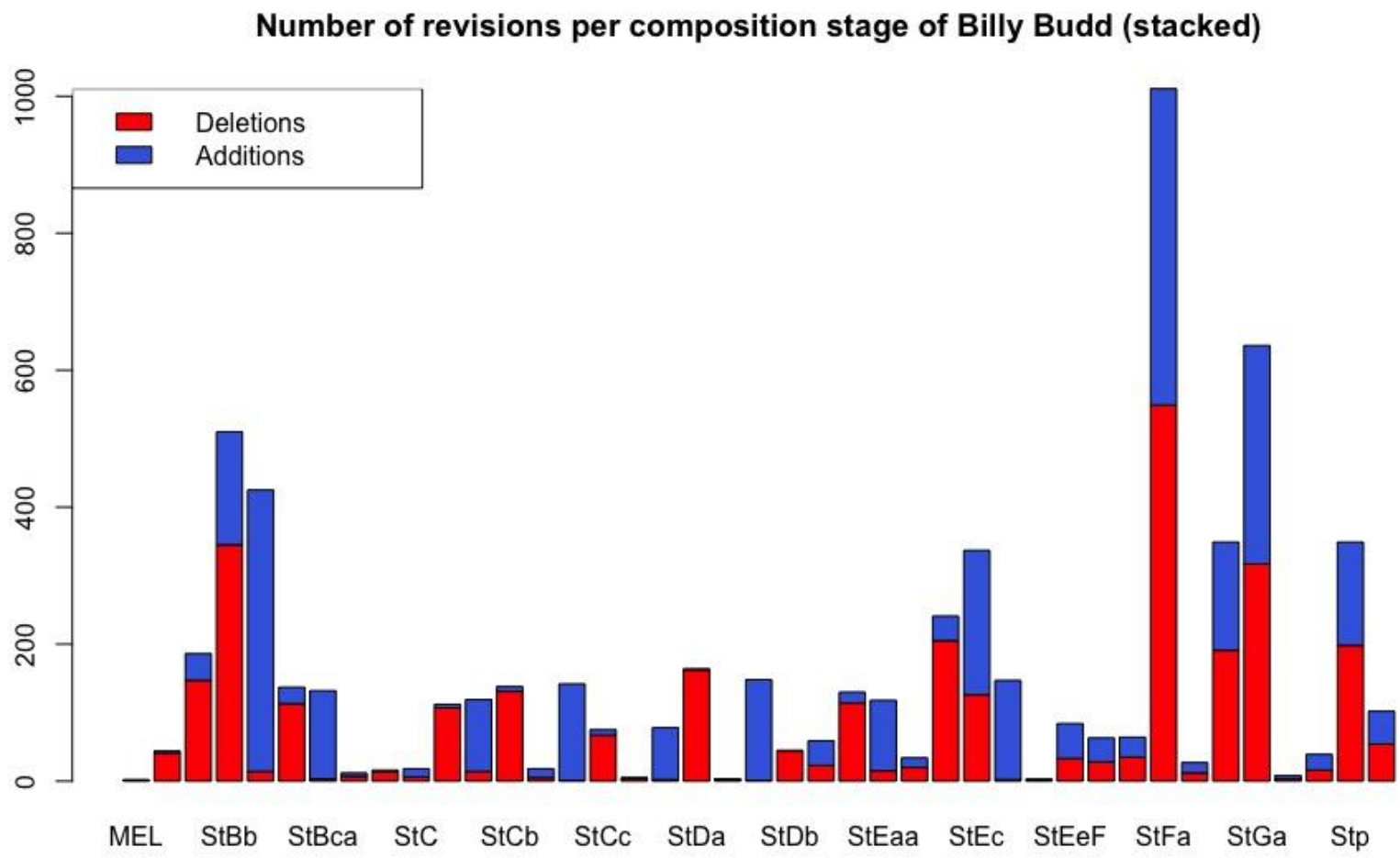
Revision, Negation, and Incompleteness

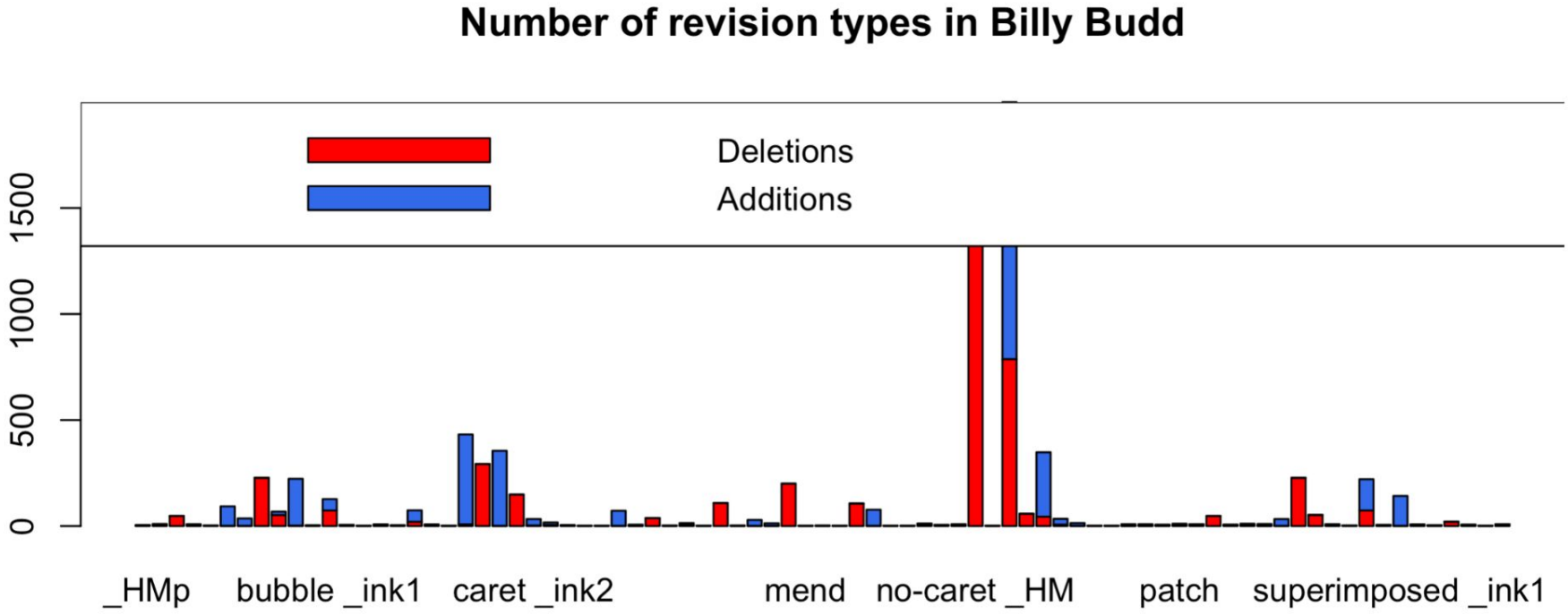

Revision type counts in the Billy Budd manuscript
Number of revisions
0
500
1500
2500
3500
deletions
additions
substitutions
restorations
Revision types

Merged data frame of deletions and additions per composition stage

```
> change.table
            MEL StB StBa StBb StBbb StBc StBca StBcb StBcCa StC StCa StCab StCb StCba
dels.table    1  41  147  345    14  113     3     7     13   6  107    14  131     5
adds.table    1   3   39  165   411   24   129     5      3  12    5   105    7    13
            StCbb StCc StCca StD StDa StDA StDaa StDb StE StEa StEaa StEab StEb StEc
dels.table      1   67     4   2  162    2     1   44  23  114    15    20  205  126
adds.table    141    8     1  76    2    1   147    1  36   16   103    14   36  211
            StEd StEef StEeF StEG StF StFa StFb StG StGa StGab StGb Stp StX
dels.table     2     1    33   28  35  549   12 191  317     3   16 198  54
adds.table   145     2    51   35  29  462   15 158  319     5   23 151  48
```


Number of revisions per composition stage of Billy Budd
Deletions
Additions
0
100
200
300
400
500
MEL
StBb
StBca
StC
StCb
StCc
StDa
StDb
StEaa
StEc
StEeF
StFa
StGa
Stp


Number of revisions per composition stage of Billy Budd (stacked)
Deletions
Additions
0
200
400
600
800
1000
MEL
StBb
StBca
StC
StCb
StCc
StDa
StDb
StEaa
StEc
StEeF
StFa
StGa
Stp


Number of revision types in Billy Budd
Deletions
Additions
0
500
1000
1500
_HMp
bubble
_ink1
caret
_ink2
mend
no-caret
_HM
patch
superimposed
_ink1

Deleted and Added Words in the Billy Budd MS

	del_word_v	Freq	add_word_v	Freq
1		**11289**		**31920**
2	the	349	the	784
3	of	191	of	448
4	a	141	to	286
5	and	129	a	284
6	to	127	in	252
7	in	105	and	246
8	it	84	his	162
9	his	82	was	157
10	that	81	as	151
11	was	66	it	147
12	as	59	that	141

Negation words in added text

15	**not**	**51**	he	107
16	is	49	at	103
17	at	43	him	98
18	him	40	**not**	**88**

76	tho	10	are	21
77	what	10	**never**	**21**

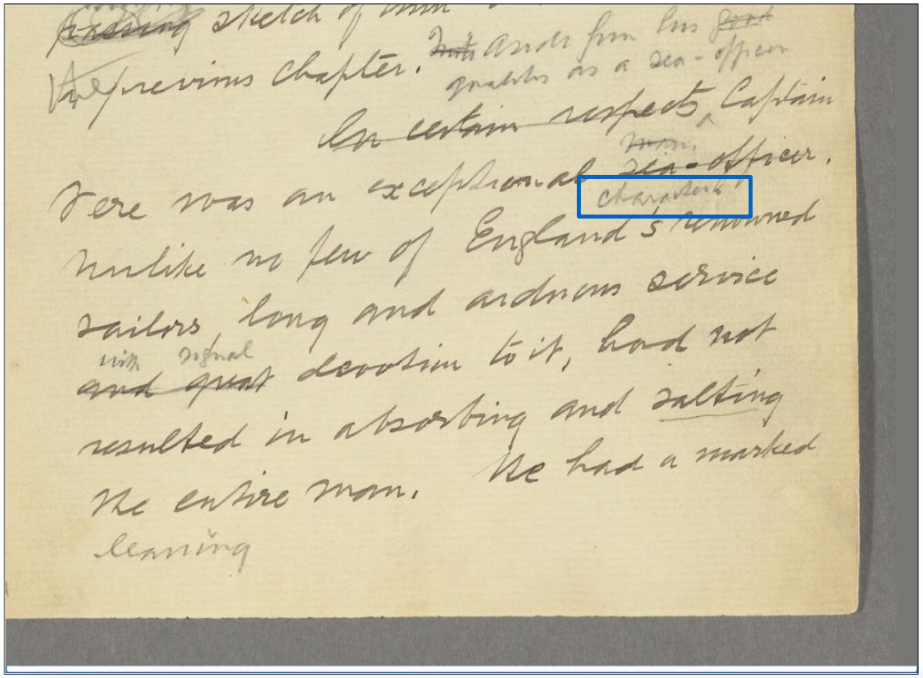
89	fleet	8	**nothing**	**18**

Other suggestive revision words

Index	deleted word	frequency	added word	frequency
130	always	6	**character**	12
221	many	4	**peculiar**	**8**
222	**mysterious**	**4**	pointer	8
254	your	4	**singularly**	**7**
301	form	3	unadulterate	6
345	passed	3	**mad**	**5**
378	th	3	**tragedy**	**5**

Next Leaf

Diplomatic Base

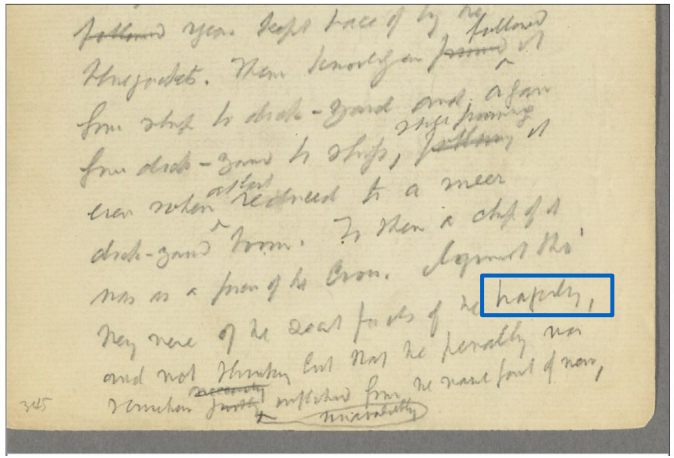


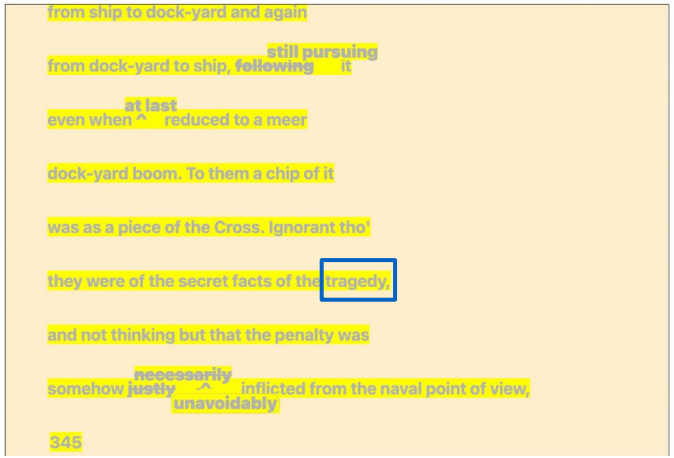
the previous ~~Quite~~ Aside from his ~~good~~ qualities as a sea-officer ~~In certain re~~

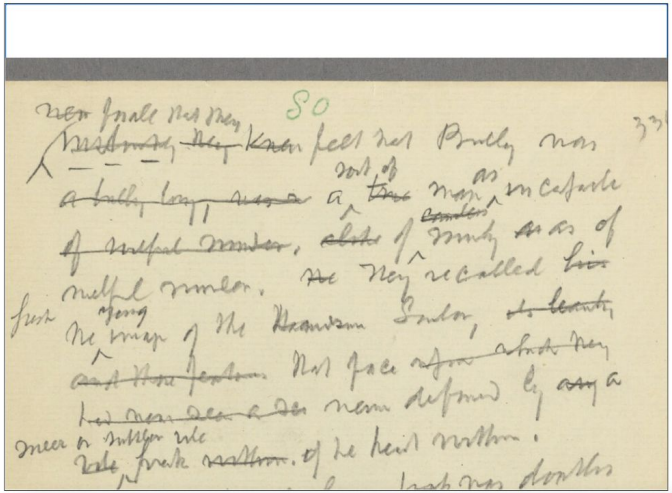
Vere was an exceptional ~~man sea-officer~~ character.

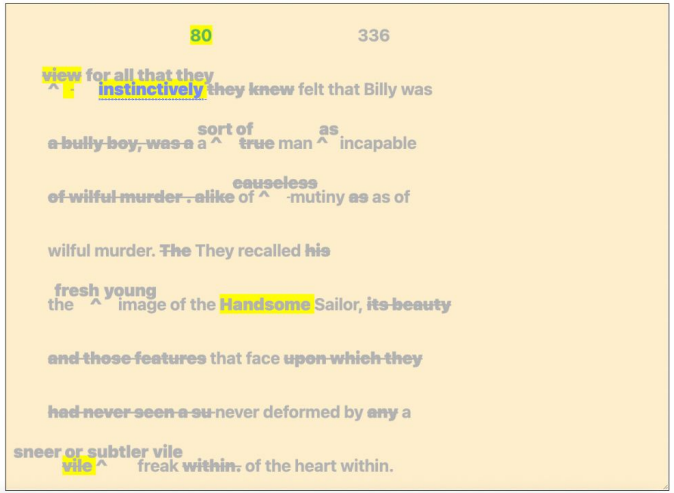
Unlike no few of England's renowned sailors, long and arduous service with ~~and great~~ signal devotion to it, had not resulted in absorbing and salting the entire man. He had a marked leaning

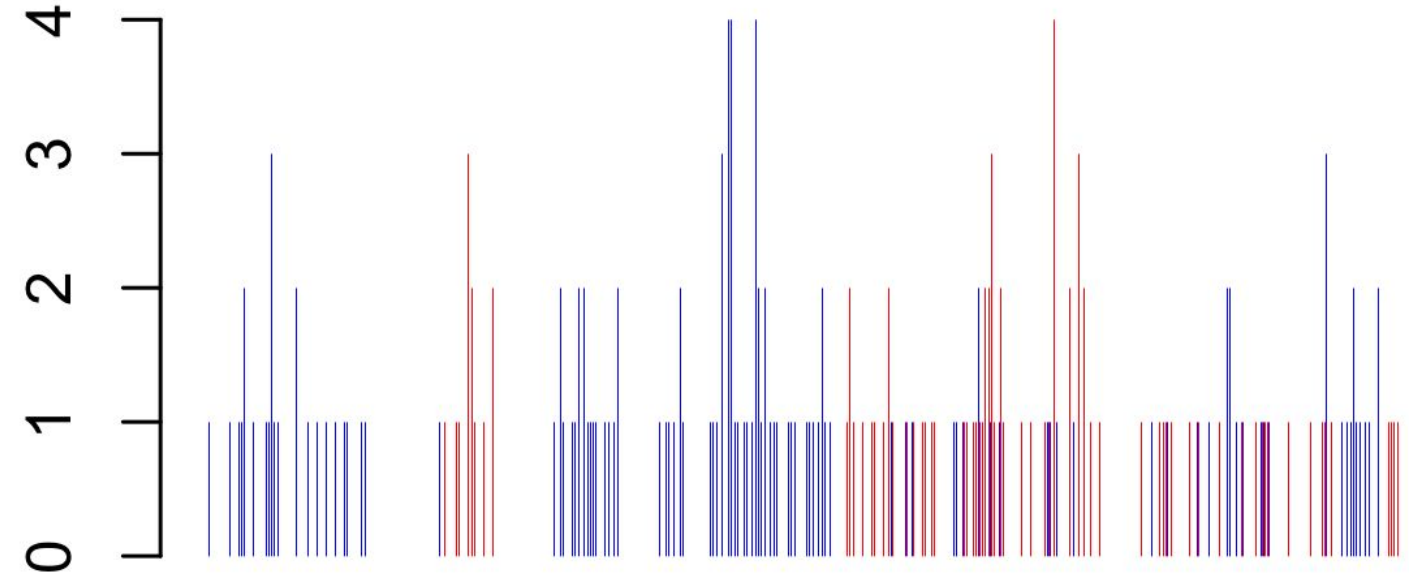
Late pencil revisions in [Chapter 30 of *Billy Budd*]



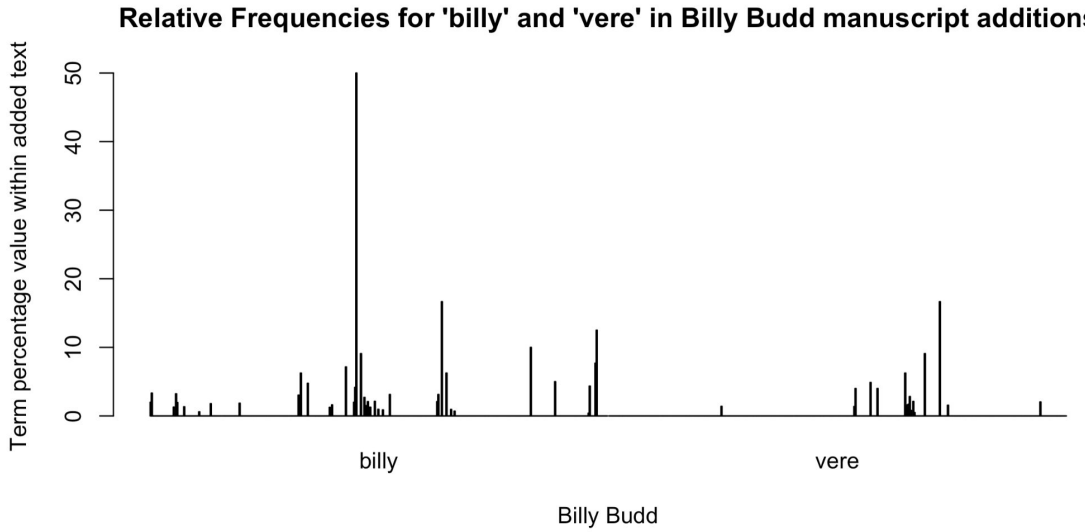


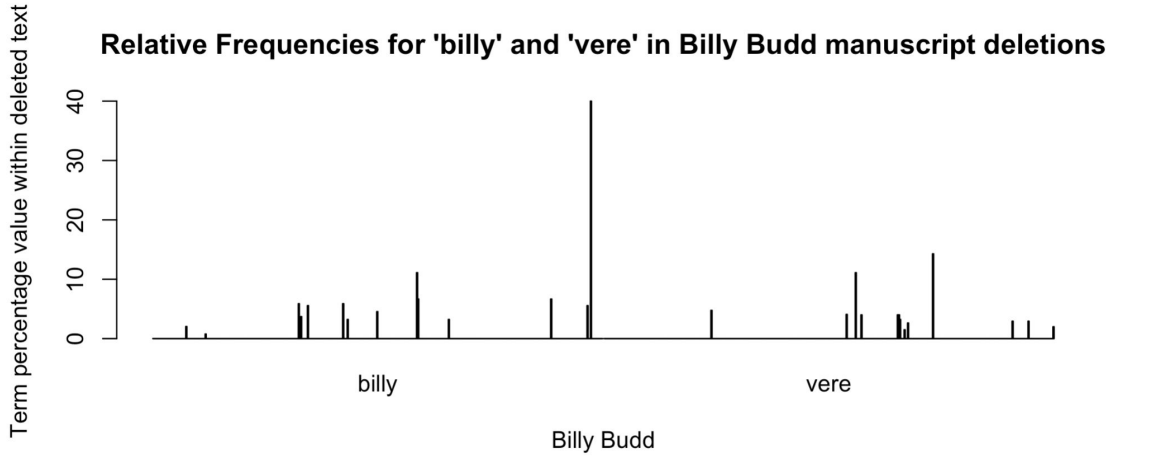




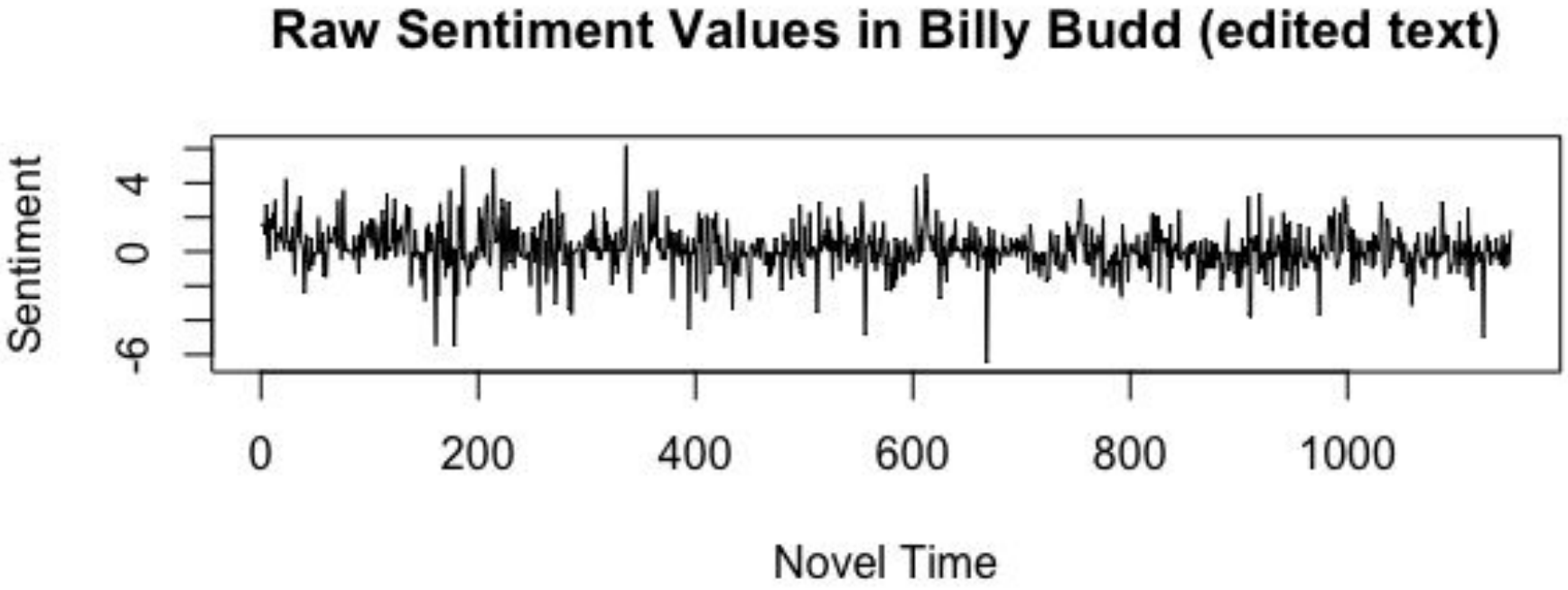


Occurrence of Billy (blue) and Vere (red) in each MS Leaf

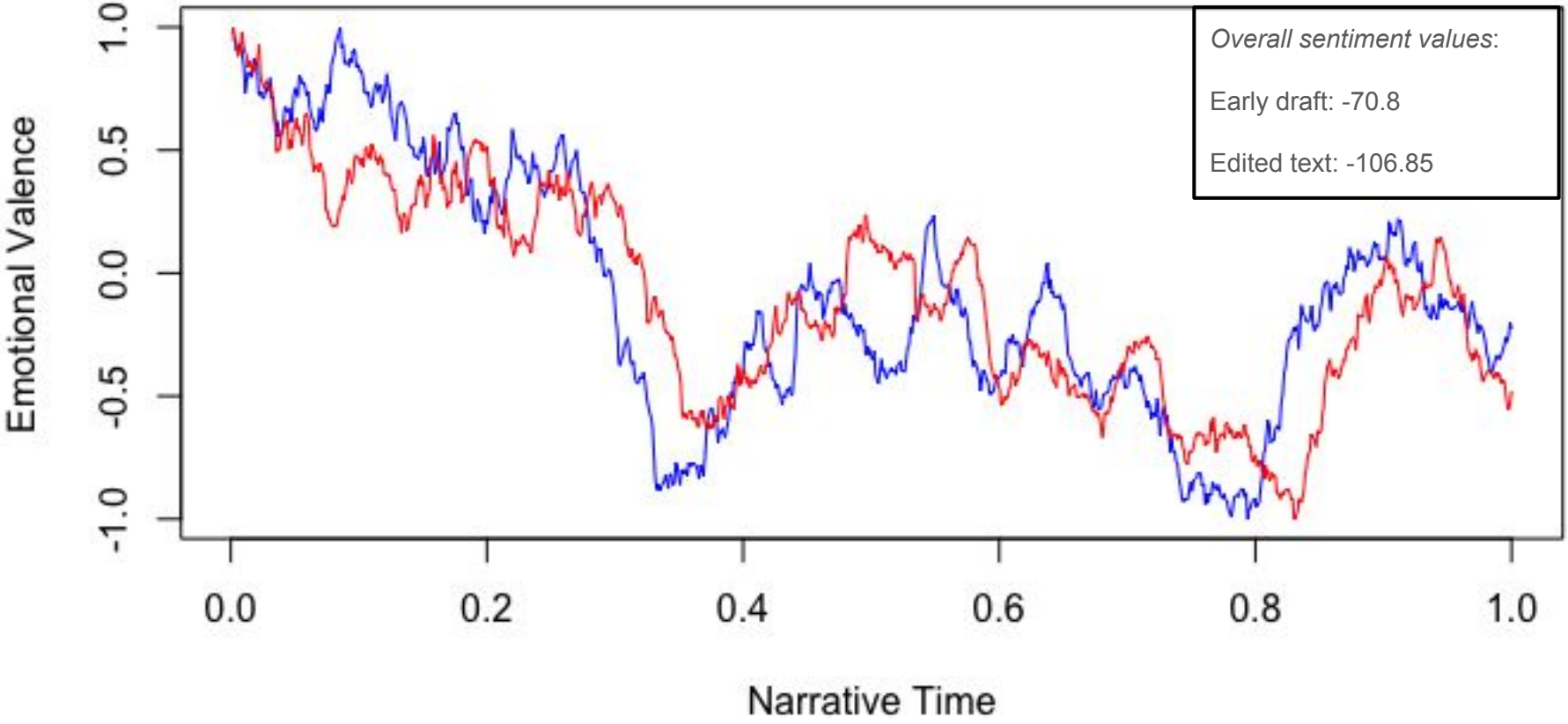

Relative Frequencies for 'billy' and 'vere' in Billy Budd manuscript additions
Term percentage value within added text
0
10
20
30
40
50
billy
vere
Billy Budd

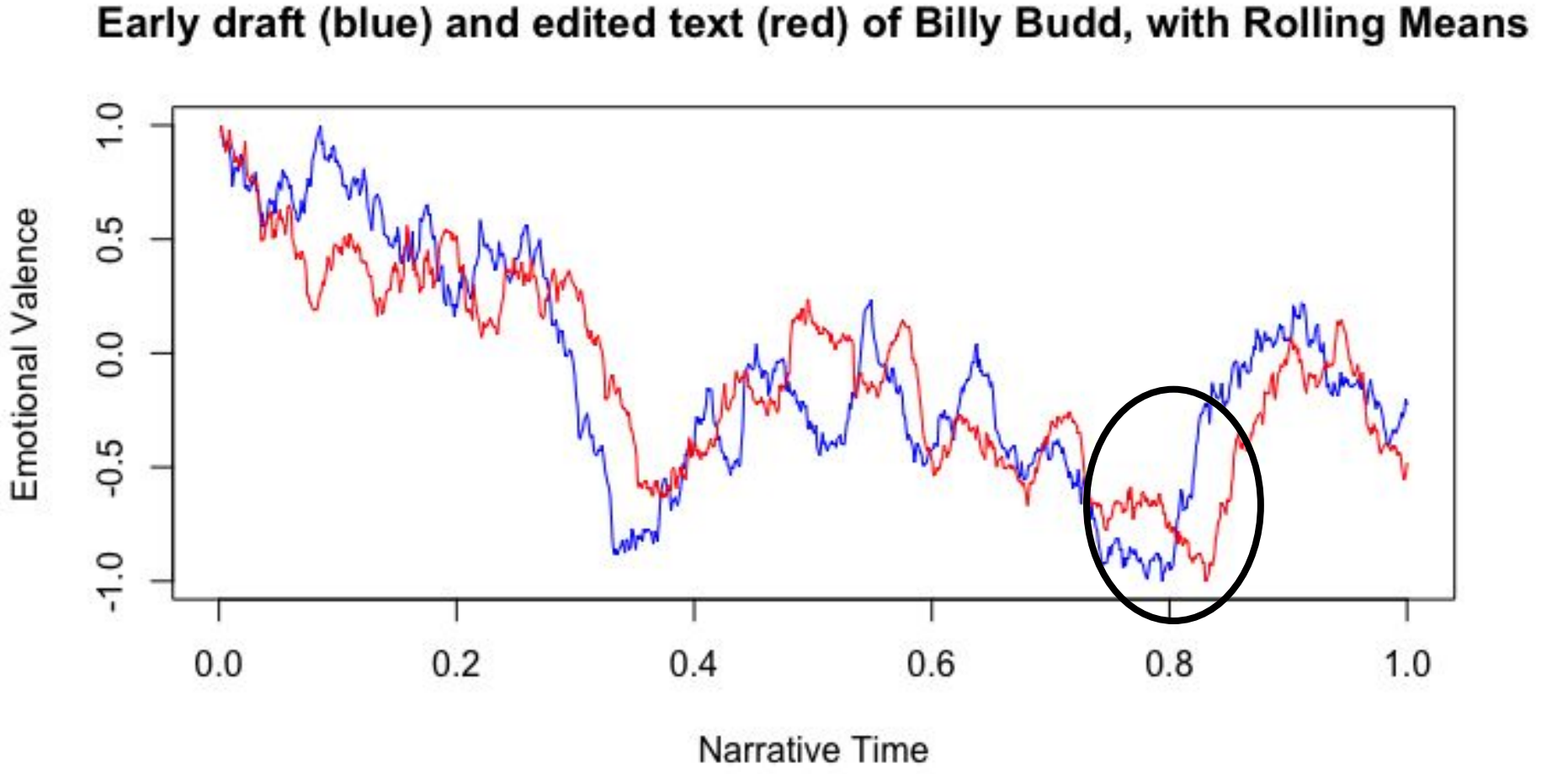

Relative Frequencies for 'billy' and 'vere' in Billy Budd manuscript deletions
Term percentage value within deleted text
0
10
20
30
40
billy
vere
Billy Budd

Negative Sentiment and Narrative Plotting


Raw Sentiment Values in Billy Budd (edited text)
Sentiment
-6
0
4
0
200
400
600
800
1000
Novel Time

Early draft (blue) and edited text (red) of Billy Budd, with Rolling Means




Early draft (blue) and edited text (red) of Billy Budd, with Rolling Means
Emotional Valence
1.0
0.5
0.0
-0.5
-1.0
0.0
0.2
0.4
0.6
0.8
1.0
Narrative Time

Emotional Valence values with corresponding sentences (sorted by descending values)

	Emotional valence	Sentence
668	-6.5	Which appeal caused but a strange dumb gesturing and gurgling in Billy; amazement at such an accusation so suddenly sprung on inexperienced nonage; this, and, it r
178	-5.5	They may add, too, that at Trafalgar it was in effect nothing less than a challenge to death; and death came; and that but for his bravado the victorious Admiral might pc
161	-5.45	Though after parleyings between Government and the ring-leaders, and concessions by the former as to some glaring abuses, the first uprising—that at Spithead—with
112	-5	Ignorant though they were of the secret facts of the tragedy, and not thinking but that the penalty was somehow unavoidably inflicted from the naval point of view, for al
556	-4.85	It was as if his precocity of crookedness (and every vulgar villain is precocious) had for once deceived him, and the man he had sought to entrap as a simpleton, had thı
394	-4.5	Now something such an one was Claggart in whom was the mania of an evil nature, not engendered by vicious training or corrupting books or licentious living, but born
911	-3.8	Not unlikely they were brought to something more or less akin to that harassed frame of mind which in the year 1842 actuated the Commander of the U.S. brig-of-war S
910	-3.75	But it is not improbable that even such of his words as were not without influence over them, less came home to them than his closing appeal to their instinct as sea-off
974	-3.7	Fed with the oil supplied by the war-contractors (whose gains, honest or otherwise, are in every land an anticipated portion of the harvest of death) with flickering splash
256	-3.65	But the sailors' dog-watch gossip concerning him derived a vague plausibility from the fact that now for some period the British Navy could so little afford to be squeam
286	-3.65	What then was his surprise and concern when ultimately he found himself getting into petty trouble occasionally about such matters as the stowage of his bag or somet
512	-3.55	And with that exclamation, of which, whether it had reference to a light puff of air just then coming over the calm sea, or a subtler relation to the afterguardsman, there is
284	-3.4	When Billy saw the culprit's naked back under the scourge, gridironed with red welts, and worse; when he marked the dire expression in the liberated man's face as wit
434	-3.4	And the retaliation is apt to be in monstrous disproportion to the supposed offence; for when in anybody was revenge in its exactions aught else but an inordinate usure

	Emotional valence	Sentence
668	-6.5	Which appeal caused but a strange dumb gesturing and gurgling in Billy; amazement at such an accusation so suddenly sprung on inexperienced nonage; this, and, it may be, horror at the accuser's eyes, serving to bring out his lurking defect and in this instance for the time intensifying it into a convulsed tongue-tie; while the intent head and entire form straining forward in an agony of ineffectual eagerness to obey the injunction to speak and defend himself, gave an expression to the face like that of a condemned Vestal priestess in the moment of being buried alive, and in the first struggle against suffocation.

Chapter 19 of *Billy Budd* (Melville Electronic Library)

Not at first did Billy take it in. When he did, the rose-tan of his cheek looked struck as by white leprosy. He stood like one impaled and gagged. Meanwhile the accuser's eyes removing not as yet from the blue dilated ones, underwent a phenomenal change, their wonted rich violet color blurring into a muddy purple. Those lights of human intelligence losing human expression, solidly protruding like the alien eyes of cer

a strange dumb] Originally, in ink, Melville wrote "an ineffectual dumb gesturing" to indicate Billy's stutter. In pencil, he revised by striking out the "n" in "an" and all of "ineffectual." replacing them with "a strange," which resulted in the inadvertent *MS:* a a strange dumb

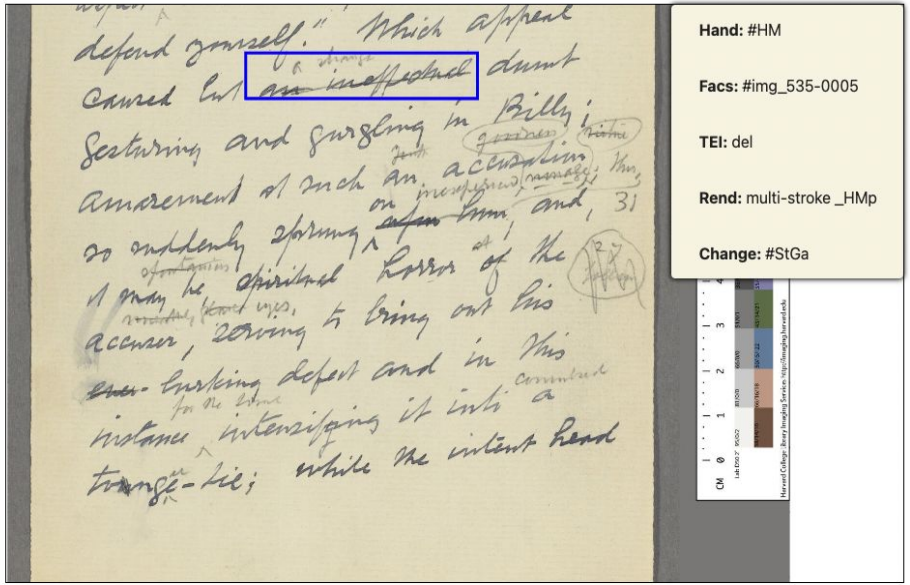
glance was one of serpent fascinati

"Speak, man!" said Captain Vere to

Claggart's, "Speak! defend yourself." Which appeal caused but a strange dumb gesturing and gurgling in Billy; amazement at such an accusation so suddenly sprung on inexperienced nonage; this, and, it may be, horror at the accuser's eyes, serving to bring out his lurking defect and in this instance for the time intensifying it into a convulsed tongue-tie; while the intent head and entire form straining forward in an agony of ineffectual eagerness to obey the injunction to speak and defend himself, gave an expression to the face like that of a condemned Vestal priestess in the moment of being buried alive, and in the first struggle against suffocation.

Previous Leaf Next Leaf

Diplomatic Base



Hand: #HM

Facs: #img_535-0005

TEI: del

Rend: multi-stroke _HMp

Change: #StGa

"Speak, man!" said Captain

Vere to the transfixed one, struck by his

even
aspect ^ more than by Claggart's, "Speak!

defend yourself." Which appeal

a strange
caused but a ~~n~~ ineffectual dumb

gesturing and gurgling in Billy;

amazement at such an accusation

on inexperienced ^ nonage ^ ; this,
so suddenly sprung ^ ~~upon~~ him, and,

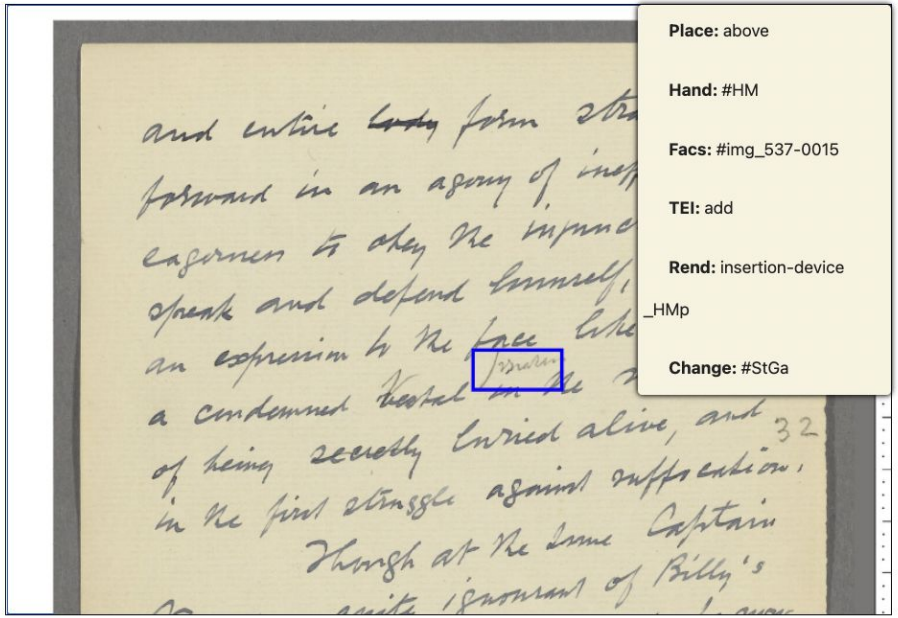
spontanious at 31
it may be, spiritual horror of the

unearthly glance eyes,
accuser, serving to bring out his

~~ever-~~ lurking defect and in this

Previous Leaf Next Leaf

Diplomatic Base



Place: above

Hand: #HM

Facs: #img_537-0015

TEI: add

Rend: insertion-device _HMp

Change: #StGa

214

and entire ~~body~~ form straining

forward in an agony of ineffectual

eagerness to obey the injunction to

speak and defend himself, gave

an expression to the face like that of

a condemned priestess Vestal in the moment

of being secretly buried alive, and

in the first struggle against suffocation. 32

Though at the time Captain

Vere was quite ignonrant of Billy's

Code and References

The **R code** for this talk can be accessed here.

Access the ***Billy Budd*** **manuscript TEI** here.

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